by extension the proper ordering of society. Within Hinduism it covers a wide range of meanings, from the correct performance of rites to caste rules. For Buddhists it means the universal truths as contained in the teachings of Buddha Sakyamuni. Ashoka, however, gave the word an entirely new spin, by promoting it as a code of ethics, a 'moral law' that he wished all his subjects to follow, irrespective of their religions.

6 Ven. Shravasti Dhammika, *The Edicts of King Asoka*, 2009.

7 Harry Falk, *Asokan Sites and Artefacts*, 2006.

8 Harry Falk, 'Remarks on the Minor Rock Edict of Asoka at Ratanpura', *Jnana-Pravaha Research Journal* XVI, 2013.

9 There is a strong case for Emperor Ashoka's Suvarnagiri being the hilltop upon which the present Bellary Fort now stands, believed to have been built over the remains of a Buddhist stupa – the 'golden hill' from which he sent out his scribes and stone-carvers north, south, east and west during his South Indian tour. The case is further strengthened by the fact that when the Erragudi MRE was first discovered by a mining engineer in 1928 a set of Ashoka's major rock edicts were also found carved on several rock surfaces higher up on that same hilltop. Only here at Erragudi have two sets of Ashokan edicts been found on the same site.

10 R. L. Mitra, 'Beef in Ancient India', *Indo-Aryans*, 1881.

11 My special thanks to the independent scholar Virchand Dharamsay, author of *Bhagwanlal Indraji: the First Indian Archaeologist*, 2012.

12 Andrew Stirling, *An account, geographical, statistical and historical, of Orissa proper, or Cuttack*, 1822.

13 *Epigraphia Indica*, Vol. XX (1929-30), 1933.

14 Ibid.

15 Only with the rise of the Vishnu cult does Shri become Lakshmi, whereupon she is relegated to the role of benign consort and goddess of wealth and prosperity,